

Getting through the gatekeeper.

How to navigate recruiters, HR screens, and hiring managers — what they're actually looking for, what eliminates candidates before a human speaks to them, and how to get from inbox to interview.

IF YOU TAKE NOTHING ELSE AWAY FROM THIS GUIDE

The five things that matter most

- Retained, contingency, and in-house recruiters have different incentives. Knowing which you're talking to changes how you engage.
- 75% of applications are filtered by ATS before a human reads them. Keyword matching is not optional.
- The HR screen is not a real interview. Its only job is to eliminate candidates with red flags. Don't disqualify yourself.
- Hiring managers care about one thing: will this person make my life better or worse? Everything else is secondary.
- The fastest path past every gatekeeper is a warm introduction from someone they already trust.

The hiring process has more layers than most candidates realize — and each layer has different people with different incentives trying to do different things.

Understanding who you're actually talking to at each stage — and what that person's job actually is — changes every conversation you have in the process.

75%

of applications filtered by ATS before a recruiter reads them
Jobscan, 2023

7 sec

average time a recruiter spends on initial résumé review
The Ladders / ThinkHQ Eye-tracking Study

WHO YOU'RE ACTUALLY TALKING TO

Three types of recruiters — three different conversations

RETAINED SEARCH

Paid upfront by the company to fill one specific role. Works exclusively. Motivated to find the perfect candidate for their client — not to place you. Engagement: fit this mandate or don't waste their time.

CONTINGENCY

Paid only when a placement is made. Often submits multiple candidates to multiple companies. Motivated to move quickly. Can be your ally if you're a strong fit — they want to place you as much as you want to be placed.

IN-HOUSE (CORPORATE)

Company employee focused on filling open reqs efficiently and protecting the hiring manager's time. Motivated by speed and quality. Most likely to use ATS filtering and structured screens. Relationship matters more than with external recruiters.

How to identify which type you're dealing with

If they work at the company — in-house. If they're at a named search firm (Spencer Stuart, Korn Ferry, Heidrick, Russell Reynolds, boutique equivalents) and the role is senior — retained. If they're at a firm that represents many companies across functions — contingency. When in doubt, ask directly: "Are you the retained search firm for this role, or are you presenting multiple candidates?"

What to say to each type

To a retained recruiter: specific fit and credibility first. They're presenting to a board or CEO and need to feel confident you're right, not close. To a contingency recruiter: your availability, your openness to be submitted, and your clarity about what you want — they can't place you effectively if they don't know. To in-house: enthusiasm for this company specifically, not for the category of role. "I've been following your work in X for two years" lands. "I'm exploring senior roles in the space" doesn't.

NEXTCHAPTER TOOL

Victoria's Route to Role identifies which recruiter type covers your target role, surfaces the specific boutique firms in your function, and helps you craft the right first message for each type. Available at launchyournextchapter.com

THE ATS — BEFORE ANYONE READS YOUR RÉSUMÉ

The filter most candidates don't know exists

Applicant Tracking Systems filter applications against the job description before a recruiter sees them. The logic is keyword-matching — not quality assessment. A strong candidate whose résumé doesn't contain the right terminology will be filtered out by a system that never reads a sentence.

How ATS filtering actually works

The system scans for keywords from the job description — required skills, tools, certifications, title variants. It compares frequency, placement, and exact matches. "Led cross-functional teams" is not the same as "cross-functional team leadership." The job description contains the exact vocabulary you need. Use it.

- Identify the 10-15 most significant keywords in the job description
- Check your résumé: how many appear verbatim? Add the gaps — don't fabricate, but use their language
- Put keywords in context, not in a keyword dump at the bottom — modern ATS systems penalize that
- Spell out acronyms and include the abbreviated form: "Search Engine Optimization (SEO)"

NEXTCHAPTER TOOL

Resume Tailor analyzes any job description and highlights exactly which of your accomplishments are most relevant — and flags which keywords are missing from your current résumé. Paste the JD URL or text and Victoria does the rest.

ATS formatting that causes problems

Systems parse text — they don't read design. Format choices that eliminate candidates before a human reviews them:

- ✗ Headers and footers (often not parsed — put your contact info in the body)
- ✗ Tables and columns (some parsers read left column, skip right column entirely)
- ✗ Images or graphics of any kind
- ✗ Text boxes in Word documents
- ✗ Unusual fonts or special characters in section headers

Always submit a plain .docx or PDF version along with any designed résumé. Many companies request one or the other explicitly.

THE WARM PATH BEATS THE ATS EVERY TIME

The surest way to bypass ATS filtering is a referral from someone inside the company who passes your résumé directly to the hiring manager. A warm introduction converts at 5× the rate of a cold application and reaches a human immediately. If your LinkedIn network includes anyone at the company — or anyone who knows the hiring manager — that conversation is worth more than 20 ATS-optimized applications.

THE HR SCREEN

What it actually is — and how to pass it

The HR screen is a filter, not a substantive interview. Its job is to eliminate candidates who would waste the hiring manager's time: comp misalignment, location issues, obvious culture gaps, candidates who can't articulate why they're interested. The right strategy is to not be eliminated — not to impress.

What the HR screen is actually looking for

In roughly priority order:

- Comp expectations in range (ask early — it saves everyone time)
- Location and remote/hybrid alignment
- Can explain their background clearly in 2–3 minutes
- Reasons for leaving current or last role that don't raise flags
- Genuine interest in this company specifically (not just the function or level)
- No communication or behavior issues in the call itself

The comp question — answer it correctly

HR will ask about compensation expectations early. The standard advice ("don't give a number first") is partly right and increasingly outdated. Refusing entirely wastes both parties' time. The better approach:

- ✓ Know your target total comp number, fully calculated, before the call
- ✓ Give a range — "\$175K–\$200K base, depending on the full package" — not an exact number
- ✓ Include total comp context: "I'm focused on total compensation, not base alone"
- ✓ If their range is below yours: "That's below where I'm targeting. Is there flexibility, or should we both save time?"

NEXTCHAPTER TOOL

Victoria's HR Screen Prep generates the 15 most common HR screen questions for your function and level — with coached answers that get you to the hiring manager round without disqualifying yourself.

How to answer "why are you looking?"

Three sentences: what changed, what you're looking for, why this role specifically. Don't editorialize about your last company. Don't be vague ("exploring opportunities"). Don't give more information than the question requires.

IF YOU WERE LAID OFF

"My role was eliminated in a restructuring — [X% of the function / the team was consolidated]. I've taken the time to be intentional about what I'm looking for, and this role is a strong fit because [one specific reason]."

Say it once. Move on. Do not apologize or over-explain.

IF YOU LEFT VOLUNTARILY

"I reached the natural end of what I could contribute in that role and was ready for the next challenge. I've been looking for [specific type of role] and this one stood out because [one specific reason]."

IF YOU LEFT UNDER DIFFICULT CIRCUMSTANCES

"The role and I were not the right fit for each other, and we parted ways. I've had time to reflect on what I do best and where I create the most value, and I'm looking for [specific type of role]. This one is interesting because [specific reason]."

Do not elaborate on the details. If pushed: "I'd rather focus on what I'm looking for than on what didn't work. I'm happy to share references who can speak to my best work."

What the person who actually decides cares about

Hiring managers are almost always interviewed out. They've talked to many candidates, heard many versions of the same stories, and developed strong pattern recognition for the difference between a candidate who will deliver and one who will sound good until they start.

What a hiring manager is actually asking in every question

Behind every interview question is one of three concerns:

- **Can you do the job?** — Do your actual skills match what this role actually requires?
- **Will you do the job?** — Are you genuinely motivated, or are you treating this as one of many options?
- **Will working with you make my life easier or harder?** — Self-awareness, reliability, communication style, how you handle difficulty

Structure every answer to address the underlying concern, not just the surface question.

What sets candidates apart at the hiring manager level

- ✓ They've done actual research — on the company, the team, the product, the competitive position — not just read the About page
- ✓ They ask questions that demonstrate they've thought about the role from the inside out
- ✓ Their career stories follow a clear structure: situation, what they did, measurable result
- ✓ They're specific — not "I led a team" but "I built a six-person team from scratch in eight months and reduced our deployment cycle from two weeks to three days"
- ✓ They ask what the first 90 days should look like and confirm alignment on expectations

NEXTCHAPTER TOOL

Interview Practice generates hiring manager-specific questions for your function and level, with a company research brief before each interview so you walk in with actual insight — not surface knowledge. Available at launchyournextchapter.com

The backdoor approach

The fastest path to the hiring manager's attention is through someone they already know and trust. Before applying to any role, check your network: Does anyone you know work at this company? Know the hiring manager? Know a leader on the team? One message from a trusted contact carries more weight than 50 perfect cold applications. This is not manipulation — it is how hiring actually works at the senior level.

- Export your LinkedIn connections CSV and search for company names
- Search LinkedIn for employees at target companies and see mutual connections
- Message your connection: "I'm exploring [role] at [company]. Do you know anyone on the team, or would you feel comfortable making an intro?"

NEXTCHAPTER TOOL

The Warm Path Finder searches your LinkedIn CSV for connections at any company you're targeting — and surfaces the message to send for each one, calibrated to how well you know them.

AFTER THE INTERVIEW

What most candidates skip

Send a thank you note — a specific one

Generic thank you notes are ignored. Specific ones are remembered. Reference one thing from the conversation that was meaningful to you. Confirm your interest in one sentence. That's it. Send within 24 hours. Most candidates don't bother — which means the ones who do stand out by default.

THANK YOU NOTE STRUCTURE

"[Name] — thank you for the time. [One specific thing from the conversation that resonated.] I'm genuinely interested in the role and the team, and I look forward to the next step."

Four sentences maximum. Do not add new qualifications or renegotiate in the note. It is a relationship gesture, not a second interview.

NEXTCAPTER TOOL

After logging an interview in NextChapter, Victoria asks you two or three questions about what came up in the conversation — then generates a personalized thank you note in your voice.

Following up on silence

If you haven't heard back by the timeline they gave you, follow up once — one message, professionally. If they gave no timeline, wait seven business days after the interview for the first follow-up. After that: two-week intervals, maximum two follow-ups total before you move on.

- Follow up with the recruiter or HR contact — not the hiring manager directly, unless they invited you to
- One sentence: confirm continued interest, ask for a timeline update
- No escalation language — "I wanted to check in" is fine; "I need to know soon" is not

THE MISTAKES

What eliminates candidates at each stage

- ✗ **Applying without checking the network first.** Every application through a warm referral converts at dramatically higher rates. Spend 10 minutes checking before you click Apply.
- ✗ **Sending the same résumé to every job.** Keywords that get you through ATS are role-specific. A résumé optimized for one job description performs significantly better than a generic one.
- ✗ **Talking too much in the HR screen.** The HR screen is a filter for red flags. Verbose answers create more opportunities to raise one. Answer directly, briefly, and wait.
- ✗ **Not researching the company before the hiring manager interview.** "Tell me what you know about us" is a real question. Candidates who answer with what they read on the About page get filtered out.
- ✗ **Not sending a thank you note.** Most candidates don't. Among those who do, specific notes stand out immediately. It takes four minutes.
- ✗ **Following up too aggressively.** Two follow-ups on a reasonable timeline is professional. More than that is a red flag about judgment and self-awareness.